The exchange of military hardware is another area that has an important bearing on building friendly relations between countries. Our strategic partnership with countries like the US, Russia and others has been enhanced by military weapons and equipment transfers. We need to have a strategy of helping our smaller neighbours achieve a reasonable capability of defence against the challenges they face. We must remember that in case we fail to seize the opportunity, someone else will fill the vacuum and meet their needs. I am also of the opinion that whatever we give to another country should be our best indigenous products that are currently in service with our defence forces, even if we are gifting the equipment or undertaking the transfers at nominal prices. This would help in strengthening our ties and keeping inimical forces at bay.

When I was in Algeria, many requests were made for us to help them overhaul their Soviet-origin weapon platforms and equipment. I conveyed those requests to our government, but our response was tardy. Our armed forces have acquired a high level of expertise in optimization of Russian tanks, guns, aircraft, ships, submarines and other equipment. We have innovated many techniques of employing this hardware, which has astounded even the Russians at times. This expertise is something many countries that have similar equipment are looking for. We must make best use of this advantage and build bonds and enduring relationships.

Another important dimension of military diplomacy is the active participation of Indian armed forces in UN peacekeeping operations. We have been the largest contributors to such operations, beginning with the first deployment in Korea in 1950. Our aspiration for a permanent seat in the UN Security Council has been reinforced by the sterling performance of our armed forces in forty-plus peacekeeping missions all over the world; our professionalism in these operations has won universal praise for us. We have provided brigade-group-sized forces in missions at Korea, Congo, Somalia and Sierra Leone, and a large number of battalion groups in many other conflict-prone areas in Africa and Asia. These deployments helped to bring about peace and stability in those areas. Significantly, at the request of the UN, we made available thirteen force commanders to